Food Insecurity in Rhode Island, 2019–Present

Food insecurity in Rhode Island has risen sharply since 2019, moving from a relatively subdued, pandemic-buffered period to record highs by the mid-2020s. In 2019, an estimated 53,000 Rhode Islanders sought food assistance each month, and the state's low-income population missed roughly 11.3 million meals a year (about 6% of need); Feeding America's Map the Meal Gap methodology put the overall food-insecurity rate at under 10% in the early 2020s (9.3% in 2021), as expanded SNAP benefits, stimulus payments, and the child tax credit temporarily offset pandemic-era hardship. That cushion disappeared as emergency federal benefits were phased out in 2022–2023: monthly food-assistance seekers climbed to about 75,000 by 2023, and the share of SNAP households reporting that their benefits ran out within two weeks rose to 70%, up from 49% in 2019. By 2024, the Rhode Island Community Food Bank's annual Status Report on Hunger found that 38% of Rhode Island households were experiencing food insecurity — a higher rate than at any point during the COVID-19 pandemic — with member agencies serving a record 84,400 people per month and the statewide "meal gap" growing to 42.2 million missed meals annually (16% of total need), nearly four times the 2019 figure.

The burden of food insecurity in Rhode Island is also sharply unequal across racial and ethnic lines and has continued to intensify into 2025. The 2024 Food Bank survey found food insecurity affecting 33% of white households compared with 47% of Black households, 55% of Latino households, and 47% of other households of color — disparities tied to lower wages, higher housing-cost burdens, and uneven access to safety-net benefits. Entering 2025, roughly one in three Rhode Island families were already food insecure even before a prolonged federal government shutdown disrupted SNAP payments that fall; the disruption drove emergency food assistance requests to more than 102,000 Rhode Islanders, the highest number the Food Bank has ever recorded, overwhelming pantries that were already operating at capacity. Taken together, rising housing, food, and health care costs, the unwinding of pandemic-era safety-net expansions, and the 2025 SNAP disruption have made food insecurity an acute and worsening policy problem in Rhode Island, rather than a residual effect of an earlier economic shock.